The impulse can be profoundly therapeutic. A 2024 cross-sectional study of 300 urban adolescents in north India, published on PubMed, found that higher spiritual health scores were linked to better overall wellbeing among youth. Separate 2024 studies of Indian medical undergraduates and urban youth cohorts, published in the *National Journal of Physiology, Pharmacy and Pharmacology*, found measurable levels of spiritual health linked to life satisfaction—indicating that many students use prayers, temple visits and related practices as tools for stress management and "purpose-seeking". "The need to belong is profoundly regulating," says Dr Pretty Duggar Gupta, consultant psychiatrist at Aster Whitefield Hospital, Bengaluru. "Shared ritual and rhythm can soothe a stricken nervous system, help breath settle and make people feel safe again."

QUICK ACCESS, NEW AESTHETICS

Scale and tech makes access easier. With more than 650,000 documented Hindu temples across India alongside countless other sacred sites, young travellers can choose sanctuaries that match their vibe. Slot-booked darshan and stay options on official apps let you plan a weekend like a concert—book, pay, show a pass, even stream the aarti if stuck en route. Case in point: Meera Nair, 27, a product manager from Bengaluru, stitched a Tirupati–Konark weekend between Friday evening and Monday morning, having booked special darshan and a room online. "I never cared for architecture," she says, "but the AR (augmented reality) guide at Konark made it special."

Technology is rewriting how heritage is experienced. Virtual tours recreate temples in high-resolution 3D, from the 9th-century rock-cut Maladevi in Madhya Pradesh, backed by the Department of Science and Technology's SHRI initiative, to Odisha's Sun Temple, where AR brings the Konark wheel alive. Projection-mapping transforms precincts into open-air theatres—Somnath's show narrates its restoration with lasers and 3D architectural visuals.

Public money is pushing this along. The PRASHAD scheme—short for Pilgrimage Rejuvenation and Spiritual Heritage Augmentation Drive—launched by the Union ministry of tourism in 2014–15, has so far sanctioned nearly Rs 1,800 crore for 48 projects across 27 states and Union territories. Cleanliness and safety are no longer afterthoughts: since the opening of the Kashi Vishwanath Corridor, Varanasi's temple precincts have been transformed with upgraded roads, lighting, modern toilets, clearer signage and enhanced riverfront policing. Another marquee project ahead: a 12.9-km ropeway from Sonprayag to Kedarnath, which will cut a gruelling 6–9 hour trek to just 36 minutes, reshaping access to one of India's most picturesque shrines.

What's more, temple tourism has gone couture. Spiritual travel operators now sell pilgrimages the way luxury agents sell safaris: private, paced and designed. Indian Temple Tour and Temple Yatri stitch fast-track darshan with helicopter charters. Holy Voyages and Tirtha Yatra add heritage stays—from restored havelis in Kashi to plantation bungalows down south—with on-call yoga teachers and multilingual scholar-guides.

"Char Dham searches are up 35 per cent over last year," says Rajeev Kale, president, Thomas Cook (India). "Our curated aerial darshan packages offer a faster, yet meaningful, experience for modern travellers." Even mass pilgrimages are being tailored. This year, Nikhil Bhatia, 31, a logistics entrepreneur from Delhi, did the Neelkanth Mahadev run with cousins in a chauffeur-driven limousine—complete with DJ setup, luxe vegan tiffins and scheduled cool-downs at hygiene-audited camps. But all this comes at a cost. A 'VVIP' darshan starts at around Rs 5,000 per person. A 'helihop' package for Char Dham is priced at a minimum Rs 2 lakh per person.

There are other draws. Advira Kohli, 27, a fashion merchandiser from Delhi, plans weekend temple runs purely for prasad. "I go where the food tells the story," she says. Food has its own fandom: Jagannath's mahaprasad, Tirupati laddus, Madurai's ghee pongal and langar-style kadhi-chawal in northern shrines.

So, whether in silence or in selfies, the pull is the same—a call to step away from noise and to seek something that truly matters. ■

—with Jumana Shah

CLICK, GO, PRAY

HOW TECH AND LUXURY ARE TRANSFORMING PILGRIMAGE

- **Plan:** Apps such as Uttarakhand's 'Tourist Care' (Char Dham) and Tirupati's 'TTD' have made booking darshan, rooms and special-entry passes seamless
- **Travel:** Corridor upgrades shrink travel time. The approved Sonprayag–Kedarnath ropeway will cut a 6–9 hour trek to 36 minutes
- **Experience:** Virtual tours such as Konark Sun Temple AR reveal lost details; projection-mapped light-and-laser shows at Somnath turn façades into living history after dusk
- **Safety & comfort:** Wider plazas, toilets, signage and lighting make crowds manageable. On-ground policing and cameras keep evenings safe and family-friendly
- **Premium layer:** Chartered chopper, heritage stay and scholar-guides add comfort and depth. Oxygen cans, luggage valets remove friction at altitude